

The American Scholar

Study Guide by Course Hero

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Book Basics

AUTHOR
Ralph Waldo Emerson

YEAR PUBLISHED
1837

GENRE
Philosophy

AT A GLANCE
In 1837 Ralph Waldo Emerson delivered "The American Scholar" as a convocation speech to Harvard's Phi Beta Kappa Society. In this speech he enumerated the nature and duties he believed an intellectual should have in this specific moment in history. Emerson, one of America's early well-regarded philosophers, was a founding luminary of transcendentalism, which advocated that God could be understood through inspiration gained by observation of and connection with creation, or nature, rather than by pure reason. This speech, presented to an early class at Harvard, is known as "America's intellectual Declaration of Independence," a phrase first spoken by American physician and writer Oliver Wendell Holmes (1809–94). It came at a time when America had few institutions of higher learning relative to Europe, but it predicted a rise in America's scholarly prominence because only America, in Emerson's estimation, had the democratic spirit necessary to elevate every person to becoming a fully realized intellectual.

ABOUT THE TITLE
"The American Scholar" references both Emerson's audience at Harvard and his idealized vision of an intellectual at the moment in history when he delivered the speech. He believed the America of his time represented a uniquely democratic moment in history in which every man could be encouraged to become his best intellectual self. Emerson saw this as preferable to bowing to entrenched convention or furthering hierarchies that elevated a few and suppressed the majority.

Main Ideas

The Whole Man/Scholar

Ralph Waldo Emerson was America's foremost transcendentalist scholar. The central theme of both "The American Scholar" and his larger body of work was that every thinking individual possessed within themselves all of the tools necessary to comprehend the divine interconnectedness of all things. Intuition and introspection will guide people to greater understanding. When Emerson talks about the "whole man," he means a person who has achieved their fullest potential. He contrasts this idea with the individuals who are constrained in

their thinking by their circumstances and the pressures exerted on them by the society in which they live. Emerson expands on these ideas by talking about the development of the scholar through careful observation of nature, correct inspiration from books, and an active and engaged lifestyle. Emerson believes that the fully actualized scholar is bold, creative, and, most importantly, self-assured. They learn from the past and the world around them, but they are guided by their strong character more than by pure rational thought. They understand that their duty is to lift up and inspire those around them, to relate the truth to the best of their ability, and to create new works and new insights for the age in which they live.

The Perils of Dogma and Society

Again and again in "The American Scholar," Emerson cautions his listeners against receiving other people's wisdom as truth rather than trusting their own judgment. He repeatedly warns of the danger of books smothering the intellect of a young scholar. He says they are taught to revere and repeat ancient wisdom without question rather than creating on their own. He believes older writings are always inherently bound to the time and place of their creation. While they may still contain truth, they become increasingly distant and alien to the mind reading them as time goes on, and new works are called for. In speaking of the particular duties of the scholar in the American context, he derides the vulgar greed permeating the present social system as stifling to the intellect, advancing only conformists and those hungry for power. In speaking about the virtue of action, he gives one caveat: the scholar must be self-directed, not relying on society as their moral compass. For Emerson, self-confident, self-generated creativity is the highest human enterprise, and it cannot occur within the bounds of ancient thought or social convention.

The Necessity of Action

Emerson strongly believes that scholars should not seclude themselves or confine their lives to purely intellectual pursuits. He believes everyone benefits from useful labor, not only in a practical sense but as part of the exercise of a healthy mind. Varied action will provide the scholar a variety of experiences from which to distill truth and wisdom, which will in turn inform correct and virtuous action. No person can be a whole scholar without action and engagement with life.

The Present Moment in America

Emerson concludes "The American Scholar" with his analysis of the current moment in history, into which the Harvard scholars who compose his audience will be graduating. He considers the state of America to be very poor. American intellectual innovation does not flourish because the country looks to Europe and Britain for advancement and follows where they lead. Greed and business as usual are choking out intellectual growth, which should be inspired by the beauty of nature all around. The system promotes conformity and drudgery, and the best people can hope for are the vulgar prizes of money and power.

However, he also believes that in the democratic spirit of America there exists the unique potential for the best possible state: one in which all people are equal and self-actualized. Already, the focus of literature is shifting toward an examination of the mundane and the concerns of everyday people. He envisions an America in contrast to the old world's strict social hierarchies. In this America, led by scholars confident in their own wisdom and virtue, people will inspire each other to an intellectual and spiritual awakening. Everywhere individuals, as equals, will rise to their fullest potential.

In Context

Nature and Transcendentalism

In 1836 Ralph Waldo Emerson anonymously published his central work *Nature*. In it he outlined his philosophical views, which would later form the foundations of the transcendentalist movement. He proposed that an individual could transcend their materialist existence through introspection and reflection on the divine connectedness of all things. A person who attained spiritual and intellectual mastery

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could in turn exercise greater and more directed free will to shape the world around them. In Emerson's estimation there was no better method for obtaining this transcendental state than solitary meditation on the beauty of nature, free from the distractions and conventions of society.

Transcendentalism coexisted in the 19th century with the larger Romantic movement and shared many characteristics with it—notably closeness with nature and a focus on intuition rather than pure logic—but it also differed in important ways. Transcendentalism as a movement was fundamentally both intellectual and spiritual, and it centered on a personal connection to the universal divine. It carried forward the Enlightenment's ideas of a comprehensible universal natural law, but applied it morally and advocated non-rational inspiration rather than reason as the mechanism by which the world should be understood. Unitarian Universalism also fed into the transcendentalist movement, with Emerson having previously been a minister. Unitarian Universalism emphasized an individual's personal conviction and relationship with the divine, and rejected both dogmatic adherence to creed and the concept of eternal punishment in hell. Transcendentalism was also influenced heavily by Greek thought, specifically Neoplatonic and Stoic philosophy. In particular, it extrapolated from the concept of ideal forms, which comes from the writings of the ancient Greek philosopher Plato (c. 428–c. 348 BCE). The theory supposes that the abstract, spiritual qualities of ideal forms, such as beauty, goodness, trees, flowers, and even geometric shapes, are greater than their physical manifestations on earth. Plato believed that there was a permanent reality operating behind earthly reality—which he believed was changeable and impermanent—and that everything in the permanent reality existed in its perfect form. Manifestations here, of such things as trees and triangles and the like, are only representations, not the real things themselves. From Stoicism, transcendentalism carried through an emphasis on temperance, virtuous living, and tranquility of mind.

Transcendentalism flourished briefly in the New England area of the United States in the 1830s to 1840s. In addition to Emerson, other notable transcendentalists include Emerson's protégé Henry David Thoreau (1817–62)—whose book *Walden* is a solitary meditation on nature, specifically on a piece of land Emerson owned—and writer and educator Margaret Fuller (1810–50), with whom Emerson published *The Dial*, the preeminent transcendentalist magazine. "The American Scholar" represents an application of Emerson's transcendentalist philosophy to the project of American intellectualism. It is also an artifact from an early point in the movement, and Emerson's association with Harvard was important in spreading his message and cultivating transcendentalism as a movement.

Intellectual Periods Throughout History

Emerson saw modern scholarship as the accretion and continuation of all previous knowledge, and in "The American Scholar" he characterizes different intellectual movements as humanity moving through childhood into adulthood. In particular, Emerson highlights the classical, Romantic, and "reflective" or contemporary epochs of human thought.

The classical period refers to a large period of time spanning both Greek and Roman cultures, from around 500 BCE to 600 CE. This constitutes a historical period rather than a specific movement, and many thinkers within classical literature disagree vociferously with each other. In Western education the study of art, literature, and philosophy from this period, as well as the Greek and Latin languages, is referred to as classical studies, and had been a cornerstone of Western education for centuries by the time Emerson was writing. Examples of classical thinkers include Greek philosophers such as Plato (c. 428–c. 348 BCE), Aristotle (384–22 BCE), Zeno (c. 495–30 BCE), Diogenes (died c. 320 BCE), and Epicurus (341–270 BCE); Greek poets and playwrights such as Homer (c. 8th or 9th century BCE), Hesiod (c. 700 BCE), Aeschylus (c.525– c. 456 BCE), and Roman poet Virgil (70–19 BCE); politicians such as Roman general Caesar (100–44 BCE) and Roman statesman, lawyer, and scholar Cicero (106–43 BCE); and historians such as Herotodus (c. 484– c.430 BCE). In the Medieval period Latin was a vital part of any education, as it allowed students to read both the Bible and remaining books and commentaries from the Roman Empire. Contact with the Islamic world reintroduced more Greek ideas to European thinkers, particularly the works of Aristotle, and inspired the beginning of the European Renaissance, or "rebirth" of art and culture, beginning in the 14th or 15th century. Enchantment with classical ideas inspired rationalism and scientific theories that often clashed with the preeminence of the Catholic Church and was a major influence leading to the period known as the Enlightenment.

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In the 18th century the dominant intellectual and cultural movement in both Europe and America had been the Enlightenment. The Enlightenment advocated scientific rationalism and the goals of life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. Thinkers in the Enlightenment tended to consider all knowledge to be discoverable through dispassionate logic and the scientific method. The Enlightenment philosopher John Locke (1632–1704) was a primary influence on the American founding fathers. The Enlightenment also saw a rise in secularism and deism, and many figures within the Enlightenment conceived of a universe that ran mechanically on pure, discernible scientific principles, without the intervention of God.

The 19th century saw a cultural backlash against the Enlightenment in the form of Romanticism. Instead of reason and logic, the Romantics championed intuition, emotion, closeness with nature, and the heroism of the individual rather than an ordered society. Romanticism tended to be skeptical of science and rationalism, and one of the most famous literary works of the period is Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*, in which unfettered pursuit of medical science, without the guiding hand of compassion, creates a literal monster.

In "The American Scholar" Emerson says, "historically, there is thought to be a difference in the ideas which predominate over successive epochs, and there are data for marking the genius of the Classic, of the Romantic, and now of the Reflective or Philosophical age. With the views I have intimated of the oneness or the identity of the mind through all individuals, I do not much dwell on these differences. In fact, I believe each individual passes through all three. The boy is a Greek; the youth, romantic; the adult, reflective." By the adult or reflective age, he means the moment in history in which he is giving the speech, and the philosophy of transcendentalism.

European and American Scholarship

In 1837 America, less than a century after having been a British colony, continued to lag behind Europe in terms of scholarship, research, philosophy, and scientific innovation. By the mid 1800s, some European universities such as Oxford and the University of Paris had been operating for several centuries and had produced influential scientists and thinkers such as Charles Darwin (1809–82), Louis Pasteur (1822–95), Sir Humphrey Davy (1778–1829), John Stuart Mill (1806–73), and Karl Marx (1818–83). Well-to-do Americans who wanted to reach the highest levels of learning and culture often toured and pursued further study in Europe. In addition to universities, Europe boasted numerous scientific societies, such as the Royal Society of London and the French Academy of Sciences, which reviewed and financed scientific endeavors and provided intellectuals a chance to collaborate and compare with their peers. This includes such notable American examples as President John Quincy Adams (1767–1848), writers Washington Irving (1783–1859) and Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (1807–82), and painter Mary Cassatt (1844–1926). Emerson himself traveled to Europe to study and reevaluate his philosophy.

Harvard, where Emerson was educated and where he delivered his "The American Scholar" speech, is the oldest university in America. Initially established in 1636 with a first graduating class of nine students, it was created explicitly as a religious institution to train clergy members. By 1837 it also boasted a medical school, a law school, and a divinity school and had educated eight signatories to the U.S. Declaration of Independence and two U.S. presidents. It was considered one of the best universities on the North American continent, but it was still small compared to the best European universities.

Emerson delivered "The American Scholar" against this backdrop of American scholarship being seen as provincial compared to its European counterparts. The theme of a distinctly American scholarship separated from European thought bookends the speech. As Emerson declares: "Perhaps the time is already come. … Our day of dependence, our long apprenticeship to the learning of other lands, draws to a close."

Author Biography

Birth, Education, and Life in the Church

Ralph Waldo Emerson was born in Boston, Massachusetts, on May 25, 1803. Emerson's father, a clergyman, died when Ralph was seven. Emerson spent much of his early life training to follow his father into the clergy. He graduated from Harvard College in 1821 then attended Harvard Divinity School in 1825

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but left after becoming ill. He was sanctioned to preach in the Unitarian sect, a branch of Christianity that worships God while rejecting the divinity of Jesus Christ, in 1826. By 1829 he was a fully ordained Unitarian minister. Three years later, in 1831, after his wife Ellen Tucker's death from tuberculosis, Emerson left his work with the church. Even before her death, however, Emerson had begun to question whether life in the clergy was the best way for him to pursue devotion to God.

After the Clergy

In 1832 Emerson set out on a tour of Europe. There he became acquainted with several contemporary writers and thinkers, including philosopher John Stuart Mill (1806–73) and author Thomas Carlyle (1795–1881). Invigorated by his travels, Emerson launched his career as a lecturer upon his return to the United States late in 1833. Some of his early lectures, on themes concerning nature and natural history, were the foundation of his first publication, *Nature*, which appeared in 1836. It was a defining text for the members of the American transcendentalist group. The movement was called *transcendental* because it stressed that to know God and understand the self, a person had to look both inward and outward—to the soul and to nature—to realize the full extent of God's work. The identity of transcendentalism as an American movement was important to Emerson, who argued in his 1837 speech "The American Scholar" that intellectuals in the United States had a calling to develop their own distinctive philosophies without European influences.

Most Active Years

Emerson settled in Concord, Massachusetts, in 1834 and married Lydia Jackson in 1835. During the 1840s he continued to write and publish prolifically. In this most productive period of his life, he continued to develop his transcendentalist philosophy and helped promote the work of similarly minded authors, most notably Henry David Thoreau (1817-1862). Emerson was involved in the creation and running of the transcendentalist journal, *The Dial*. Emerson's own work in this period included the essays "Self-Reliance" and "Experience" and the poem "Threnody," written after the death of his first-born son in 1842.

Emerson continued to lecture, and he conducted speaking tours both in the United States and abroad in Britain and France. Emerson's work brought him fame and financial success, and his strong moral purpose led him to become an outspoken abolitionist and a supporter of the Union cause in the American Civil War (1861–65).

In his later works, however, Emerson became more conservative. For example, *The Conduct of Life* (1860) shows Emerson's evolution from a controversial individualist to a more rounded thinker concerned about the state of wider society rather than with the spiritual life of the individual. Emerson's work in the abolitionist movement was doubtless a factor in this evolution. This wider social consciousness is perhaps best exemplified in *The Conduct of Life*, with Emerson's emergence as a champion of the Civil War as a means to bring about a national rebirth.

Later Years

In Emerson's old age, his health, especially the decline of his memory, limited his writing and lecturing. He died on April 27, 1882. Known as the "Sage of Concord," Emerson is chiefly remembered as one of the founders of American transcendentalism and as a skilled poet, essayist, and lecturer concerned with individualism, the soul, and the prospect of fully appreciating the nature of God and creation through solitary contemplation. Emerson's legacy as an influence on his contemporaries and on later American writers is formidable.

Key Figures

Alfred the Great

Beginning with Alfred the Great, all the key figures in "The American Scholar" can be considered to be minor. No one figure is more important than the rest. Emerson makes numerous allusions to writers, philosophers, and others to support his ideas about the nature and duties of the American intellectual.

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Full Key Figure List

Key Figure	Description
Alfred the Great	Alfred the Great (849–99) was a king in southwest England who was responsible for ordering the compilation of the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle. He is also known for his promotion of literacy and education.
Roger Bacon	Roger Bacon (c. 1220–92) was an English philosopher, scientist, and reformer who criticized the dogmatic theology of his day. He is one of the first advocates of the scientific method.
Robert Burns	Robert Burns (1759–96) was a Scottish poet famous for his commonplace settings and his use of Scottish vernacular. His most famous poems include "To a Mouse" and "Address to a Haggis."
Thomas Carlyle	Thomas Carlyle (1795–1881) was a Scottish historian and essayist. His notable works include a history of the French Revolution.
Geoffrey Chaucer	Geoffrey Chaucer (c. 1342–1400) was one of the first writers to utilize vernacular English for his compositions. His most famous work is *The Canterbury Tales*.
Cicero	Marcus Tullius Cicero (106–43 BCE) was a Roman politician, lawyer, and writer who was committed to the principles of the Roman Republic. Cicero is associated with the philosophy of Stoicism.
William Cowper	William Cowper (1731–1800) was an English poet who embraced everyday life as his subject matter.
Georges Cuvier	Georges Cuvier (1769–1832) was a French anatomist who founded the discipline of paleontology.
Humphry Davy	Humphry Davy (1778–1829) was an English chemist who isolated several elements and compounds and created the mining safety lamp.
John Dryden	John Dryden (1631–1700) was an English poet, playwright, and literary critic.
Epictetus (55–c. 135)	Epictetus (55–c. 135) was a Stoic Greek philosopher who often discussed religion and the ways to live one's best life. The Stoic philosophy stressed logic and freedom from passion.
John Flamsteed	John Flamsteed (1646–1719) was the first Astronomer Royal of England.
Edward Gibbon	Edward Gibbon (1737–94) was an English historian most known for his influential work *The History of the Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*.
Johann Wolfgang von Goethe	Johann Wolfgang von Goethe (1749–1832) was a German poet, playwright, writer, statesman, and scientist and is widely considered the greatest writer in the German language.
Oliver Goldsmith	Oliver Goldsmith (1730–74) was an Irish author, playwright, and essayist. He was noted for his charming simplicity.
Sir William Herschel	Sir William Herschel (1738–1822) was a British astronomer who developed new techniques for observation of stars and discovered Uranus.
Samuel Johnson	Samuel Johnson (1709–84) was an English writer, critic, poet, and lexicographer, or one who writes or edits a dictionary. He published one of the first dictionaries of the English language.
Carolus Linnaeus	Carolus Linnaeus (1707–78) was a Swedish naturalist who pioneered the classification of organisms.

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John Locke	John Locke (1632–1704) was an English philosopher most famous for the idea of the social contract. In this view, people voluntarily surrender some of their autonomy for the protection and stability of living in a group. He was a major intellectual influence on the American constitution.
Andrew Marvell	Andrew Marvell (1621–78) was an English satirist and metaphysical poet.
Isaac Newton	Isaac Newton (1643–1727) was an English scientist responsible for advances in calculus and physics. He is widely considered one of history's greatest scientists.
Plato	Plato (c. 428–c. 348 BCE) was a Greek philosopher who relayed most of the teachings of Socrates (c. 470–399 BCE) and mentored Aristotle (384–322 BCE).
Alexander Pope	Alexander Pope (1688–1744) was an English poet and satirist.
William Shakespeare	William Shakespeare (1564–1616) was an English playwright and poet, widely considered one of the best and most influential writers in the English language.
Emanuel Swedenborg	Emanuel Swedenborg (1688–1772) was a Swedish philosopher, scientist, and theologian. He wrote an ethical reinterpretation of Christianity claiming the prophesied second coming of Jesus was conceptual rather than literal.
William Wordsworth	William Wordsworth (1770–1850) was an English Romantic poet who frequently wrote on the beauty of nature.

Plot Summary

Introduction

Ralph Waldo Emerson opens his speech by welcoming students back from the holidays. He contrasts their gathering with those of the ancient Greeks, who met for competitions and to hear history recited. He also compares it with the gatherings of troubadours, medieval poets who met to exchange poetry, and with their contemporaries in Britain and Europe who currently meet to advance science. So far they are only meeting in friendship, but he hopes it can be something more. He hopes now is the time when America will stop its "long apprenticeship to the learning of other lands" and fulfill the promise of its own unique intellectual tradition. As such, the subject of his speech will be the American scholar and what the current age has illuminated about the scholar's character and their hopes.

Emerson introduces an allegory that he claims comes from an ancient fable. Once, he says, there was a whole single "Man" whom the gods divided into separate people, the way the hand is divided into fingers. This was done so humanity could accomplish more. The "whole Man" can still be found as the sum of all individual people: the farmer, the priest, the politician, the soldier. Each person performs their task, and by doing so, is able to advance society. However, in the present day, individual people are not an embodiment of the "whole Man." Individuals have become divided. People are occupied only with their own routine tasks without being able to connect to the "complete Man" they once were. They are only concerned with, and capable of, pursing their trades. "The priest becomes a form; the attorney a statute-book; the mechanic a machine; the sailor a rope of the ship," Emerson says. Only the scholar is the "delegated intellect."

In the case of the scholar, this manifests not as "Man Thinking," as Emerson puts it, but as a person who thoughtlessly repeats the insights of others. Emerson invites the listeners to contemplate the scholar and rhetorically asks, "Is not indeed every man a student?" and "Is not the true scholar the only true master?" He quotes the Greek philosopher Epictetus (55–c. 135) by saying, "All things have two handles: beware of the wrong one." For Emerson, there is a distinction between a true scholar, whom every person has the capacity to become, and someone who merely performs the appearance of scholarship through memorization of other people's thoughts. He proposes to discuss the main influences on the development of a true scholar.

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Section 1

Emerson says that the first and most important influence on the mind of a scholar is observing nature. Nature is full of infinitely repeating cycles that demonstrate to the attentive mind a similarity to the endless human spirit. In watching the world around them, young scholars learn how to classify and see the interconnectedness between things. They learn to discern that things function by "a law which is also a law of the human mind." No matter the subject, the scholar will observe that nature and human thought reflect each other, and the insights of one into the other allow the scholar to understand and classify all of creation.

Emerson says that studying nature will suggest to the scholar a root cause of all they see, one not merely scientific but universal and spiritual, from which both they and nature spring forth. The human soul and nature are complementary, "that nature is the opposite of the soul, answering to it part for part," and in studying nature, the scholarly mind will expand to encompass both an intellectual and spiritual understanding of God's interconnected universe, of which they are an inseparable part.

Section 2

The second major influence on the mind of the present scholar, Emerson says, is the thinking of the great minds of the past. This is transmitted through art, literature, and writing, especially through books. The great thinkers of the past learned from the world around them and recorded their thoughts poetically. The act of writing made it possible to transmit their ideas to future generations, to live on figuratively inside new minds. However, no writer can completely escape the mindset of their era, nor can later readers escape their own, and so the transmission will always be imperfect. There will be assumptions in the original work, as well as things that do not translate or are not relevant in later centuries. Each generation "must write its own books."

This, Emerson says, is where "mischief" sets in. People come to view the books of the past as perfect and cling dogmatically to old texts without adding innovation. Young scholars are taught to repeat the wisdom of previous great thinkers. They do not appreciate that the greatest thinkers of the past age were also once just young scholars challenging the wisdom of a previous generation. Instead of being "*Man Thinking,*" Emerson says, these people merely love books.

He contends that well-used books are "the best of things," but books misapplied are "among the worst." The value of books, in Emerson's estimation, is to awaken and inspire the soul of the reader. Every person has the ability, the right, and the higher duty to create, and, at their best, books inspire their readers toward creation. However, they also have a danger of inspiring slavish imitation. Emerson mentions that readers must glean only what is authentic in literary works, such as in Greek philosopher Plato's (c. 428–c. 328) works and in English writer William Shakespeare's (1564–1616) poetry and plays.

Emerson states that books should not be the primary way a scholar learns. Scholars should be interacting with the world first and reading only at night. However, Emerson hurries to assure the listener that he has no intention of underrating books. He says books bring a completely unique pleasure in their consumption because they connect minds across time. He talks about the joy and surprise at finding one's own thoughts similar to those of someone living centuries before. The reader is joined to the author through time as if to another piece of the collective intellect of humanity. The author could not have foreseen the future but left it nourishment anyway, in the way some insects do for their unhatched young: "But for the evidence thence afforded to the philosophical doctrine of the identity of all minds," says Emerson, "we should suppose some preestablished harmony, some foresight of souls that were to be, and some preparation of stores for their future wants, like the fact observed in insects, who lay up food before death for the young grub they shall never see." The pleasure in reading gives a sense of intellectual commune with the past as it nurtures the soul. The active and creative human mind can find intellectual nourishment in any sort of book. However, scholars should read judiciously, deciding for themselves what parts of any book are universally true and what parts are specific to the time a work was written. Also, some things, such as the sciences, can only be learned by "laborious reading" and drill in universities. However, the greater purpose of these institutions should always be to gather great young minds and let them mingle with each other while encouraging creative thought. Everything else universities do, in Emerson's opinion, is pure pomp and show.

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Section 3

Emerson says there is a prevailing myth that a scholar ought to be a recluse and a "valetudinarian," or hypochondriac. In this view, a scholar should be someone whose labor is entirely mental and who shies away from physical exertion. He believes people tend to view scholars, especially priests, as effeminate and practically useless. Action, he argues, is an important part of scholarship, without which the full truth and beauty of the world cannot be apprehended. Without action, a person is not whole.

People learn by experience and by confrontation with the obstacles of the world. They learn to conquer fear by facing and overcoming challenges. "Drudgery, calamity, exasperation, want," Emerson says, "are instructors in eloquence and wisdom." The mind is always processing a person's experiences into new information and ways of thinking.

While a person can look back objectively and with emotional distance on actions taken in childhood, a person cannot comprehend actions as they take them. Only hindsight can transform experiences into an understanding of universal truths. Without diverse action, thoughts become circumscribed and too narrow. Then it is possible for the scholar to find the vein of thought they had invested their lives in dried up with nothing for them to fall back on. Life and action outside of academia expose the scholar to a rich variety of wisdom and vocabulary.

However, the greatest "value of action" is that it is a resource to the scholar. Thought and action undulate like the ebb and flow of breath, like all things in nature, and each strengthens the other. The active scholar always has the resources to live. Without life, there is no scholarship. If the scholar lives life well and virtuously, it will not only improve the world but also their thoughts. Emerson believes in the instincts of humanity toward positive change. These instincts exist outside of and are sometimes hampered by the lessons of civilization. He claims the energetic heroes of modern thought do not emerge from the exemplars of antique cultures. The ancestors of Shakespeare and of Alfred the Great (849–99), an English king who promoted learning, were uncultured barbarians during the height of Greek and Roman culture. He only puts one limitation on useful action: the thinking person should not subsume their own judgment to popular morals. When a scholar's own mind and soul tell them what is right and what is wrong, they should trust their own judgment, even if their community or their country tell them otherwise.

Conclusion

Having gone over the influence of nature, books, and action on the scholar, Emerson proposes to discuss the scholar's duties. The scholar's duties require confidence and self-trust. A scholar's careful analysis of the human mind may not bring him the immediate fame of, for example, famous astronomers John Flamsteed (1646–1719) and Sir William Herschel (1738–1822), who have concrete facts to present. However, the scholar's work is still useful even when they labor in obscurity. Their dedication to intellectual labors may leave them out of popular fashion, with little time or money. Nevertheless they are, in Emerson's estimation, engaged in the most important work it is possible for humans to do. Scholars' work is to listen both to their own hearts and to reason with regard to the events of their time and to spread the knowledge they have heard and lessons they have learned.

According to Emerson, the scholar should not bend to comply with the popular sentiments of their day. They should trust themselves and their instincts, which they have honed through observation, study, and action. The solitude they may feel in this is an illusion. They will discover this when they reach out with their poetry and speeches and find a resonance with their audience, who will see the truth in what they are attempting to convey.

Self-trust allows the scholar to be virtuous, brave, and free. They should not let fear keep them away from difficult or political questions. They should understand that the pretension of the world exists only so long as they allow it to exist. Too often scholars are cowed by the notion that things are fixed and that there is nothing new or worthwhile they could do. The person who can shape the mind, however, is greater than the person who can shape matter. Emerson lists a number of great thinkers whom he feels have made an art of conveying the truth of the world.

Emerson wonders if his audience will follow him into his conclusion. He believes that the current state of humanity is degenerated and very far from the light that could lead it back to where it should be. Only a few achieve their full potential. Too many people are content never to develop themselves as long as they can associate themselves with a leader.

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Furthermore, people have thoughtlessly accepted wealth and power as the highest human goals, but if someone awakens their power to think for themselves they will reject them. The highest goal of a person should be the awakening of the universal man dwelling inside all men. Emerson says, "Each philosopher, each bard, each actor, has only done for me, as by a delegate, what one day I can do for myself." The scholar of today has already consumed all the great thoughts of the past and requires the creation of something new.

Emerson comes to his final point: the duties and opportunities of the scholar at this moment in history. He relates the ages of intellectual progress: classical, Romantic, and now "Reflective or Philosophical," and compares them to the stages of life for an individual: childhood, adolescence, and adulthood. People call the present "the age of Introversion," but Emerson doesn't think this is necessarily bad. The discontent of current thinkers is just outgrowing the ideas of the past generations. Writers and artists are beginning to look around at what was considered too commonplace for attention and finding beauty and meaning in the everyday lives of everyday people. These things are as interesting, wondrous, and, most importantly, true as any epic written in the past. All things are connected and governed by the same universal laws. Emerson draws particular attention to philosopher Emanuel Swedenborg (1688–1772) as one of the best thinkers of the current time. He attempted a complete ethical theory of modern Christianity and dwelt particularly on real but unpleasant problems such as mental illness, filth, and fear.

The current age is also notable for its focus on the individual and the inalienable rights every person has. Emerson believes this is as it should be. "If there be one lesson more than another, which should pierce his ear," he says, "it is, The world is nothing, the man is all." Every individual has access to all the wisdom and knowledge they need, from their own capacity to learn from and interpret the world. Because of this democratic spirit, the American Scholar will be the leader of the next wave of thought, despite current predictions to the contrary. People consider America to be in the intellectual thrall of Europe, its scholars too timid, and its culture too focused on greed. The atmosphere of avarice, drudgery, and complacency grinds down the country's brightest minds, even driving some to suicide. However, the remedy for this is the steadfast confidence of the true American scholar. If they boldly defend what is true and virtuous, they can elevate the entire nation. For the first time in all of human history, a community of whole and actualized individuals can support and inspire each other and the world.

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“” Quotes

"We do not meet for games of strength … like the ancient Greeks … nor for the advancement of science, like … the British."

— Narrator

Ralph Waldo Emerson is addressing the audience, composed of students and faculty at Harvard University. His opening compares their current gathering to historical meetings of great thinkers and the current scholarly climate of Europe. This sets up the conclusion, in which he will discuss the unique duties and advantages of the American scholar.

"Our day of dependence, our long apprenticeship to the learning of other lands, draws to a close."

— Narrator

Emerson states that it is necessary for America, at this time in history, to develop its own unique intellectual tradition and to stop relying on Europe.

"Him Nature solicits with all her placid, all her monitory pictures. Him the past instructs. Him the future invites."

— Narrator

Emerson is describing the perfect scholar, someone who has meditated on nature, learned from the past, and been inspired toward the future.

"The book is perfect; as love of the hero corrupts into worship of his statue."

— Narrator

Emerson warns about treating books as inviolable canon. The point should be to engage the ideas of the original writer, not to slavishly replicate them.

"The English dramatic poets have Shakespearized now for two hundred years."

— Narrator

Emerson believes that innovation and creativity are the highest intellectual virtues, and he is accusing literature of being derivative.

"Character is higher than intellect."

— Narrator

One of the core precepts of transcendentalism is that true wisdom, knowledge, and truth come not from rational analysis, but from an intuitive understanding based in self-reflection.

"There is virtue yet in the hoe and the spade, for learned as well as for unlearned hands."

— Narrator

Emerson advocates for scholars to engage in physical labor, not just for its practical benefit, but because they become better people for it.

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"The office of the scholar is to cheer, to raise, and to guide men by showing them facts amidst appearances."

— Narrator

Emerson believes that the principal duty of the scholar is to inspire others toward self-actualization.

"It is a mischievous notion that we are come late into nature; that the world was finished a long time ago."

— Narrator

Emerson emphasizes that there is still a good deal of intellectual and practical work for the scholar to do. The whole and awakened person is able to affect and to better the world around them.

"What a testimony ... is borne to the demands of his own nature, by the poor clansman ... who rejoices in the glory of his chief!"

— Narrator

Emerson is bemoaning the circumstances in which a small number of people are provided the resources to reach their highest potential while the many around them are denied the same opportunities. Despite their own oppression, people often feel invested in those few who are allowed to live their fullest life, and Emerson considers this a profound tragedy.

"They ... will perish to add one drop of blood to make that great heart beat, those giant sinews combat and conquer."

— Narrator

Emerson believes that people surrender their own rights and dignity to emotionally attach themselves to heroes and leaders rather than investing in their own improvement.

"It is one light which beams out of a thousand stars. It is one soul which animates all men."

— Narrator

Emerson believes in the interconnectedness of all things. According to him, all people are connected to a universal divine.

"The literature of the poor, ... the meaning of household life, are the topics of the time. It is a great stride."

— Narrator

The focus of literature in the time in which Emerson is delivering his speech has shifted toward more commonplace subjects. Emerson views this as intellectual and spiritual progress. He sees it as a sign that a more democratic humanity may attain a state in which fully actualized scholars inspire each other as equals.

"The near explains the far. The

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drop is a small ocean. A man is related to all nature."

— Narrator

Because all things are connected, the study and observation of any single part of nature reveals truths about the whole of nature, humanity, and the universe.

"This confidence in the unsearched might of man belongs, by all motives, by all prophecy, by all preparation, to the American Scholar."

— Narrator

Emerson believes that America alone has the potential to create a democratic and equal society of whole scholars. He believes it will be difficult, but it can and should happen. All of history has been leading up to it.

Symbols

Parts of a Single Body

Ralph Waldo Emerson believed that all nature and all of humanity spring from a common source, and in every person resides the necessary tools to work toward comprehending the whole. He uses the metaphor of separate fingers on the same hand to allude to springing from the same connected source yet being divided into individuals. He carries the metaphor further by describing being unable or unwilling to contemplate the larger source in terms of amputation. He speaks of individual parts divorced from their larger context: "a good finger, a neck, a stomach, an elbow, but never a man."

Insect Life Cycle

In several places Emerson compares the intellectual development and behavior of scholars to the life cycle of insects. In addition to referencing the metamorphosis of butterflies, he describes those who write their thoughts down in books in terms of burrowing insects leaving nourishment for offspring that they will never see. Emerson believed deeply in observing the natural world, and the insect metaphors combine allusions to some of nature's most dramatic changes and most instinctual behaviors.

Glossary

antiquity *(n)* the distant past, especially those time periods in which Greece and Rome were at the height of their power, roughly 500 BCE to 600 AD

degenerate *(adj)* having lost cohesion into a less favorable state, especially with regards to morality

empyrean *(n)* heaven; an ideal place or state

maxim *(n)* a repeated saying or statement of purpose; a motto

monitory *(adj)* giving admonition or a warning

promulgate *(v)* to spread information about an idea or belief system

subordinated *(adj)* in service of and inferior to another thing or idea

transmute *(v)* to transform from one thing into another; to turn one substance into another through alchemy

valetudinarian *(n)* a person who is fearful about their health; a hypochondriac

zenith *(n)* the point at which a thing is most powerful or successful; the highest point a star reaches in the night sky from the viewpoint of an observer

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